

Tax filing guide for PhD students dealing with fellowships and student employment — Action Checklist

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CLASSIFY YOUR INCOME SOURCES

- ❑ **Classify Your Income Sources:** Download your complete banking history from January 1 through December 31 of the tax year and review every single deposit you received because institutions often pay through multiple systems and you may have forgotten some income sources. **Classify Your Income Sources:** Sort every deposit into one of five categories (fellowship payments, stipend advances, research assistantship wages, teaching assistantship wages, or grant funds) because different income types have different tax rules and treatment. **Classify Your Income Sources:** Create a spreadsheet with columns for Date, Amount, Source Name, Source Type, and Form Expected (W-2, 1098-T, other, or not sure) so you have a working document that tracks all your income in one place. **Classify Your Income Sources:** Note the exact dollar amount and source for each payment so you have specific records rather than estimates when you file your taxes and claim your income. **Understand Your Tax Forms:** Recognize that the 1098-T reports payments made to your institution for tuition and fees, not money that went into your bank account, because this is a common source of confusion for PhD students. **Understand Your Tax Forms:** Check which box your institution uses on your 1098-T (Box 1 shows amounts received, Box 2 shows amounts billed) because these numbers often differ significantly from what you actually received. **Understand Your Tax Forms:** Note that Box 5 only shows scholarships applied to tuition, not your total scholarship amount, so your actual scholarship could be much larger than what appears on the form. **Understand Your Tax Forms:** Locate your W-2 from your institution's payroll office or student employment portal and confirm it matches your employment income, because the W-2 and 1098-T report completely different things. **Prepare to File Correctly:** Determine whether you need forms beyond the basic 1040, because PhD students with fellowship income may need Schedule 1 and those with foreign income may need Form 8843. **Prepare to File Correctly:** Use your spreadsheet to match each income source to the correct tax form, entering each W-2 income on your return and noting fellowship amounts separately. **Prepare to File Correctly:** Verify your W-2 income matches your actual deposit history by comparing it against your pay stubs and bank records, because payroll errors do occur. **Prepare to File Correctly:** Create a dedicated folder for organizing your 1098-T, W-2s, and bank statements so everything is accessible when you begin preparing your taxes and you do not scramble for documents at the last minute.
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- ☐ **Check the Full Guide:** This step is described in detail in the companion guide — open phd-student-tax-filing.md and review the relevant section.
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UNDERSTAND YOUR TAX FORMS

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PREPARE TO FILE CORRECTLY

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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.